

CHESS MASTERY LIBRARY | FIRST EDITION

The Library Guide

How to turn reading into better decisions

THE PROMISE

Use a small permanent library without turning study into passive consumption.

VOLUME 01 OF 15

READ | RECALL | DECIDE | RETEST

What this volume should change

- Choose the right volume for the weakness in front of you.
- Run a short daily session built around recall and one decision.
- Measure transfer to games instead of pages completed.

HOW TO STUDY

Read one section. Close the PDF and state its decision rule from memory. Solve the position lab before viewing the answer. Revisit the lab after two days and again after one week.

Inside this volume

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This volume is an original teaching synthesis of established chess ideas. Positions marked illustrative are designed to isolate a decision, not to replace full-game analysis. Board diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork from Lichess, licensed GPLv2+.

The library has one job

Chess knowledge matters only when it changes a choice you make at the board. Read to acquire a usable cue: what to notice, what question to ask, and what action to test. A beautiful explanation that never reappears in your thinking process is entertainment, not training.

Position cues

- Concept: a durable model of how positions work.
- Cue: the visible feature that should trigger the concept.
- Decision: the move-selection behavior the cue changes.
- Feedback: evidence from an exercise or game that the behavior improved.

PRACTICE RULE

After every study page, close the PDF and say the decision rule in your own words. Then invent one position where the rule would be wrong.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not collect rules as commandments. Every strategic rule is conditional; tactics, king safety, and concrete move order can override it.

The recommended reading path

Start with the Thinking System, then alternate tactical and positional material. Openings make more sense after you understand development, pawn breaks, and piece activity. Endgames belong early because they make calculation and piece value clearer, not because you must memorize hundreds of positions.

Position cues

- Weeks 1-2: Thinking System, Tactical Patterns, Calculation Method.
- Weeks 3-4: Evaluation, Pieces and Squares, Pawn Structures.
- Weeks 5-6: Attack, Defense, and Opening Principles.
- Weeks 7-8: both endgame volumes and Practical Play.
- Thereafter: Training volume plus targeted rereading from your games.

PRACTICE RULE

Study one volume for several days. Revisit its labs before moving on. Interleave old material so recognition must survive a change of topic.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Reading everything in order once creates familiarity, not mastery. The library is designed to be cycled through.

A twenty-minute daily session

A useful session is short enough to repeat and demanding enough to require thought. The default split is recall, one focused concept, one position, and a written takeaway. Stop while attention is still good.

Position cues

- 3 minutes: recall yesterday's principle without opening the PDF.
- 6 minutes: read one section slowly and identify its trigger.
- 8 minutes: solve one position and record candidate moves.
- 3 minutes: write one sentence beginning, 'In my games, I will notice...'.

PRACTICE RULE

Once a week, replace reading with a review of your notes and three old position labs. Once a month, compare the library with your recent PGNs.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

More time is not automatically better. Fatigued chess study often rehearses guessing and shallow calculation.

How to use a position lab

The answer is intentionally placed later. First reconstruct the position, name the urgent features, generate at least two candidates, and calculate the opponent's best reply. A correct move found by a poor process is not yet a reliable success.

Position cues

- Orientation: files run a through h; ranks run 1 through 8.
- Uppercase letters are White pieces; lowercase letters are Black pieces.
- Write the reason for your move before checking the answer.
- Score process separately from result: candidates, calculation, and final choice.

PRACTICE RULE

On a retry, cover your old answer. Explain why the tempting alternative fails before restating the solution.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not move pieces immediately. Visualization grows when you hold at least the first branch in your head.

A simple progress standard

You own an idea when you can recall it, recognize its trigger in a new position, use it under time pressure, and explain its limits. These are four different tests. A highlighted page proves none of them.

Position cues

- Recall: can I state the idea tomorrow?
- Recognition: do I notice when the feature appears?
- Execution: can I calculate the needed move accurately?
- Transfer: does it improve choices in my own games?

PRACTICE RULE

Mark each concept 0, 1, or 2 for recall, recognition, execution, and transfer. Revisit the lowest dimension, not the most enjoyable chapter.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

A rating change is noisy. Track repeated decision errors over blocks of at least ten serious games.

Position Lab

Do not turn the page until you have written a candidate list or explanation. Score the process separately from whether your final answer is correct.

LAB 01

Design tomorrow's 20-minute session. Name the exact volume, section, lab, and final recall question.

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

LAB 02

You understand a chapter while reading it but forget it during games. Which link in the learning chain is missing?

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

Position Lab - Answers

LAB 01

A strong plan is specific and small, for example: recall the forcing-move order; read 'Checks are not automatically first'; solve Lab 1 without moving pieces; finish by stating when a quiet candidate deserves calculation.

LAB 02

Usually recognition or execution. Create a visible cue, such as 'loose piece' or 'pawn break,' then practice positions where you must identify the cue before choosing a move. Later, test it in games.

Daily Study Card

Use this as a compact recall sheet. Say each item without looking, then open the volume only for the item you cannot explain.

- Recall one principle before opening any PDF.
- Study one section, not one whole book.
- Solve before reading the answer.
- Write one cue and one decision rule.
- Schedule a retry in two or three days.

TRANSFER TEST

During your next five serious games, mark every position where this volume's cue appeared. Improvement means you noticed the cue and used a better process, even when the game result was noisy.

CONTINUE WITH

01_Thinking_System.pdf

Personal notes
